

DEAR WATSON

IBM's cognitive computing system Watson has, thus far, been marketed primarily to the retail side of the fashion industry, however, the technology could prove to be an invaluable tool on the business (supply) end. Using the timeless Little Black Dress as an example, here are some common conundrums along the fashion vertical that Watson could provide the quick and easy answers to—by Nivara Kaykay

DESIGN

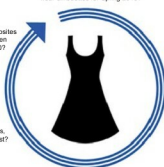
What are the trending women-wear silhouettes for Spring 2016?

MARKETING

What are the most popular websites for middle-income career women between the ages of 35 and 50?

MERCHANDISING

Among what sizes do sleeveless, above-the-knee dresses sell best?



SOURCING

I need to make a dress similar to Little Black Dress Co. Style # 123 out of a cotton-blend woven for under \$10 per garment. What are my options?

PRODUCT DEVELOPMENT

What black cotton weaves do we currently have approved in bulk at our factories?

PRODUCTION

I need a last-minute order completed for delivery by mid-March. What factories are available during Chinese New Year to work on the order?

Fig. 6: The possible applications of Watson across the apparel product lifecycle (Source: www.nivarakaykay.com)

action with the user.

Shape, prints and fabric styling.

The next requirement in fashion styling is to identify attributes like shape, print and fabric. Style principles of these attributes change with time and heavily depend on individual preferences. For example, for wearing prints, the style trend used to be only one pattern piece at a time. Later, wearing two patterns with similar shades became trendy. Other features which affect the styling are occasion and cultural background. The stylist needs to look at a number of features from different categories and classify items based on his experience and fashion sense. Updated style rules are a great data source to keep track of changes in fashion trends.

Fashion trend tracking. The stylist program needs to be highly sensitive to fashion trends. Fashion trend forecasting is vital for success in the fashion industry and always poses a bigger challenge than prediction of other fields. The highest variable is the human value.

In the fashion process, new trends start becoming popular slowly before trendsetter adoption and then reach a peak of fast social majority acceptance. These decline dramatically thereafter owing to reasons such as newer trends arrival and boredom

setting in the trend after peak.

There are two types of fashion forecasting. One concentrates on current fashion objects and makes predictions on fashion colour trends. The other is based on a longer vision, for example, black and white are never out of date regardless of season or occasion.

Attempts to predict fashion colour trends with AI techniques have seen great success. AI is capable of modelling individual boredom as memory factor of an object and memory parameter as the number of times it is used. Greater frequency of usage means more memories, and thus higher boredom and less utility.

AI methods include:

1. **Fuzzy logic.** It utilises uncertainty and approximate reasoning and works closer to human brain, providing outputs as straightforward like or dislike.

2. **Artificial neural networks (ANNs).** This is a learning method, resembling animal nervous systems, mapping input to a target output by adjusting weights. It is suitable for modelling complex styling tasks with multiple features.

3. **Decision trees.** This method is used in human decision-making models and includes tree-structured graphs that represent attributes as

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